photos with special equipment the previous day and concluded that the missiles were approximately 65 feet long.[9]

Lundahl's other aide, Sidney Graybeal, showed the president pictures of Soviet ballistic missiles photographed at a military parade in Moscow. Graybeal, a former pilot who had flown thirty-two combat missions during World War II and joined the CIA after the war to become a guided-missiles intelligence analyst, knew more about the Soviet missiles than anyone else in the room. He explained to the president that medium-range Soviet missiles with a 630-mile range were 67 feet long, while intermediate-range missiles with a range of 1,100 miles were 73 feet long. Those spotted by the U-2 were approximately 67 feet long, indicating medium-range missiles. But if they had been photographed without their 4- or 5-foot nose cones, explained Graybeal, then they might well be intermediate-range missiles. Everyone in the room who bothered to do the calculation and look at the map had reason to worry. Intermediate-range missiles could reach not only Washington and New York but also Boston, Chicago, and Denver.

"Is this ready to be fired?" was Kennedy's next question, referring to the photos just shown to him. Graybeal told the president that the missiles under discussion were not yet combat-ready. Only one missile had been photographed at a launch site. He could not locate fenced areas near launch sites, which would be expected if the Soviets had already delivered nuclear warheads. Probed by those present at the meeting, Graybeal admitted that if everything were in place, it would take the Soviets "in the order of two to three hours before they could get that one missile up and ready to go." Kennedy wanted to know more about the missiles and their readiness. He authorized additional U-2 flights, but that was not enough. Neither he nor the others in the room thought that they could simply bide their time under the circumstances. They had to come up with a plan of action.[10]

Kennedy asked Dean Rusk, who had produced the first draft of the president's statement on the discovery of the SAM sites in early September, to share his thoughts. Rusk, who had been informed about the results of the U-2 flights the previous evening, even before the news was broken to the president, had clearly given the issue a lot of thought and was now ready to propose two possible scenarios. "I do think that we have to set in motion a chain of events that will eliminate this base," began Rusk. "The question